Experiences of Suicide in Transgender Youth

Quintin A. Hunt, M.S., Jenifer K. McGuire, Ph.D., & Jory M. Catalpa

University of Minnesota

Importance:

Suicide is the 2nd leading cause of death among ages 15-25 and the 10th leading cause of all ages. Sexual minority status is a strong predictor suicidal ideation, when combined with racial/ethnic minority status this risk is even higher. The dearth (<20 articles) of literature that addresses trans* suicide has little consensus on the prevalence of suicidality in the population. Some cite the rate of suicide attempts at 41% and others cite it closer to 60%. The purpose of this study is to better understand the experiences of trans youth when they discuss their history of suicide and suicidal thoughts in order to more appropriately address future research and intervention.

Methodology:

Participants

- 85 trans-identified youth (15-26)
- Recruited from 9 cities in 3 countries
- 35% of U.S. sample identified as ethnic minority

Procedures

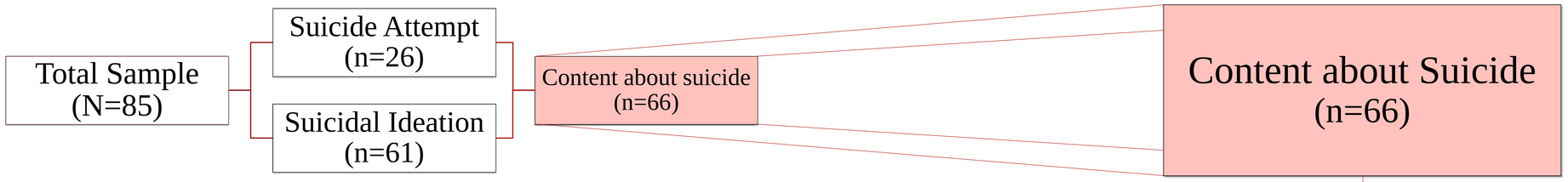
- Creation of subset of suicide-related material
  - 1) Questions related to suicide
  - 2) Searches for *kill, die, suicid*, cut, self-harm, harm*.

Analysis

- Open coding
  - Creating of categories and emergent themes
- Selective coding
  - Coding entire subset to fill these themes (looking for these themes in the material)

Results:

Participants were sorted by reported suicide attempts (26) and suicidal ideation (61) into the suicide-related subset. Four main themes emerged from this material: connection, rejection, embodiment, and self-preservation.



Connection (n= 31)

Bid to Connect

"[Suicide] was more of just the most extreme way I knew how to reach out for help."

Connection

"Having friends and the prospect of transitioning is helping a huge amount."

"I've been with the same person for quite a while now…[it's] been really helpful to have someone as a constant in my life."

Concern or Care

*"I let slip onetime I wanted a dog and my mom came home with a little dog…I was absolutely speechless…*long pause* This dog I thought saved my life really."*

Support

"I was really afraid of [my dad so I] ran away and called my mom to pick me up."

Validation

"After being able to be open and honest with [my parents] I got back on track."

Rejection (n=37)

Misgendering

"A big factor in not [going to a hospital] was I was afraid that because of my gender things might be worse."

"[The staff at the hospital] called me by my legal name even though I didn't want to be. They called me 'he' and put me with a male roommate."

Rejection

"Being gay or trans in a society that shuns them is definitely a contributing factor [to wanting to die]."

"I was so suicidal because I felt like no one understood me and I'm like, 'what's the point of me being here if nobody understand me?' "

"My mother started freaking out more about my clothing choices. I had always shopped in boy's or men's sections but after I came out it was like, 'Why don't you come over here? You're on the wrong side of the store."

Embodiment (n=44)

Control

"I hate this shell I've been placed in and I want to cut it up. To have control over some aspect of my body. It relates to my tattoos and my body art. I could control that about my body."

Anxiety

"I always felt like other people perform better than me…I always have too little or too much confidence. I'm never really at the right level of confidence."

Body

"I've definitely had a very disjointed relationship with my body…being trans is a lot about negotiating your body…It's very much about your body and your relationship with you body."

"Cutting was about being able to connect physically with my body because I felt so disassociated that I would cut and come back to that physical pain and be present. It was really difficult to do without having some kind of stimulus like that."

Self-Preservation (n=60)

Awareness

"Now I'm an adult so I have adult self harm things like drinking and smoking. It's the same thing."

"It's hard to access where my mind is was when I tried to kill myself, because my mind works differently. I can't think the same way now. I just get so exhausted from life."

Coping

"I just wanted to take myself away from going to school everyday and hearing someone say, 'oh, you are gay?' Me trying to fit in. I just wanted to end it all right there."

"[Suicide ideation] is a tool I have to keep afloat if I need to."

Self-Preservation

"I grew up not wanting to spend my life looking to the medical field that just exploits the body or my struggles mentally with depression. I want someone who loves me and actually cares about me."

Email huntx271@umn.edu for more information or a copy of the poster. For updates on the research or to download a copy of the poster and see future directions and presentations visit: z.umn.edu/mtys